

magazine



backpage
Hidden in plain sight:
India's folk jewellery

GO TO » PAGE 8

INSIDE
Arabic calligraphy's artistic
revival in South India

GO TO » PAGE 5

LITERARY REVIEW
Anne Applebaum on the
rise of autocratic regimes

GO TO » PAGE 3

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(Clockwise from below) Sushant Divgikar as Rani KoHENur; Durga Gawde takes charge "of the way I am objectified"; a drag performance; Anwesh Sahoo (left) with his peers; drag artist Nin Kala, who co-founded It Events to support marginalised talent; and Alex Mathew as Maya. (SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT)



Jishnu Bandyopadhyay

Durga Gawde was a teenager when they saw artist Nikhil Chopra take on a feminine avatar for his 48-hour performance, *Yog Raj Chitrakar Memory Drawing IX*, at the 2009 Venice Biennale. In a *Vogue* interview, they remember how "this heterosexual Indian man transformed from this super hairy masculine figure to a host of characters until he was this beautiful Victorian goddess-like lady. He did not jump from man to woman; he just kept changing."

That moment stayed with them, through years of questioning their identity, gender, and place in the world. Eight years later, another pivotal encounter happened closer to home. In New Delhi, they met Sushant Divgikar, also known as Rani KoHENur, on an electric night at Kitty Su – the pioneering, queer-friendly nightclub franchise – where she was performing alongside an American drag queen. "I didn't even know there was a drag scene in India at the time," recalls Gawde, who had just returned from Rhode Island School of Design, where their circle of friends had expanded to include queer and trans people. "We met backstage, and Rani and I had this instant connection."

By then, Gawde had discovered their fluidity when it came to gender, but wasn't considering performing on stage. "But Rani [a drag mother and mentor] helped me get out of my head and put myself out there." By 2018, Gawde became the first drag child of what would become the Hauz of KoHENur. Eventually, the sculptor and athlete also became India's first drag king, Shakti.

An art form with deep roots
Drag is art; it is also protest – a theatrical deconstruction of gender where artists use exaggerated aesthetics – multicoloured harlequin wigs, high glam makeup, glittering corsets and sky-high heels – to satirise or tweak social norms. While variations of the art form have existed for centuries, from the *onnagata* of Japanese Kabuki to the gender-agnostic actors of Bengali-Odia *jatra*, it has now undergone a massive commercial explosion. Much of this is credited to the RuPaul-isation of the craft. *RuPaul's Drag Race*, an Emmy-winning reality competition



Legal lens

Delhi-based lawyer Raghavii Shukla, a transgender woman herself, is unambiguous about the legal gaps that exist for the drag community. "Apart from social security, there is still minimal legal support," she says. "The laws of inheritance and family in India are dependent on the bio-legal relationships that people have." The current legislation does not recognise the concept of a chosen family, or a drag house. "The courts have recognised atypical families in a 2022 judgment, but that does not help with legal rights."

Workplace harassment is also difficult to legally address because drag is not formally recognised as a profession. Shukla advises houses in the entertainment business to collectivise, and register – be it as a society, trust, partnership, or Section 8 company (NGO to promote arts, education) – to avail more legal protections.

WHERE QUEER AMBITION FINDS A HOME

From KoHENur to Luna, drag mothers are mentoring upcoming talent, helping build communities, and creating safe spaces in India's shifting queer landscape

series hosted by American drag icon RuPaul, transformed drag from an underground queer sanctuary into a global phenomenon with a viable career path. While this shift provided the community with unprecedented financial stability, it also equipped performers to 'use their flair' for activism – against legislative erasure and systemic prejudice.

The Indian drag scene, more incipient in its current form, is its own ecosystem. Performers blend the technicality of Western drag with local mythology or folk forms that illustrate gender play (such as Arjuna as the eunuch Brihannala). They don't see drag as a Western import, but as a veiled set of indigenous identities returning to the limelight.

Today, it is leaping into the mainstream. International queens are touring the country, homegrown stars are gracing magazine covers, and non-queer venues are hosting major productions. Last year, *Superqueens: the Musical*, India's first drag musical, opened at The Piano Man jazz club in Delhi. The

show, directed by theatre artist Vivek Mansukhani and starring five drag queens, including Whacker Cracker (Paridhi Chauhan) and Lush Monsoon (Aishwarya Ayushmaan), was a hit. Drag artists are also booking shows at kitty parties and big festivals such as Magnetic Fields. According to the queens, payments for these performances start from around ₹5,000 per gig and go up to ₹60,000 or more.

Indian fashion is adopting the subculture's gender-bending aesthetics too, signalling a broader cultural integration. Jewellery brand Valliyan teamed up with drag artist Osheen's creative collective Dragalactiq for a show at the 2024 Lakmé Fashion Week. The performance featured Glorious Luna (Suruj Rajkhowa) and Dame Imfala (Yaiikhom Vushiel) building a world around Valliyan's 'spacebug' collection with insect-esque drag characters. Founder Nitya Arora is now a fervent advocate, frequently introducing friends and acquaintances to drag shows. "Drag adds so much value to the creative industry while uplifting queer voices," she says. "Fashion is about

fantasy; it is about self-expression and unapologetic presence. I don't think anyone does all of that more beautifully than the drag community."

Drag also acts as a major tool of inclusion, Arora adds. By turning gender into a costume that can be put on and taken off, drag reduces the "fear" associated with non-binary identities or diverse gender expressions. Performers such as Hyderabad-based Patrini Sastry, for instance, are utilising drag to lead corporate workshops on gender sensitisation and unconscious bias for global firms such as Google and Uber; queens are fixtures at high-end weddings, injecting a campy energy into traditional ceremonies. Meanwhile, digital platforms such as DragVanti have become vital archives for local drag history, and a new generation of performers is leveraging social media to



demystify gender fluidity for the Indian masses.

Drag motherhoods

Another recent development in India is drag performers coming together for kinship and to create safe spaces. A 'house' is a chosen family of drag performers and queer creatives, led by an experienced 'mother' or 'father' who mentors the younger queens and kings. Originating from the ballroom culture of New York – a queer subculture where drag performers competed – the concept is often equated with India's *gharanas*, a system of patronage and lineages in Hindustani classical music and dance.

Drag houses are known to provide shelter, community, and care. The mother teaches their child everything from makeup, choreography and community-building to navigating the gig economy. Many also help their children access medical care (such as PrEP, or pre-exposure prophylaxis, which reduces the risk of contracting HIV), mental health professionals, and pro bono legal help, when needed. On the surface, Gawde didn't need such a support system. They had grown up with parents who were visual artists and ostensibly open-minded. "My relationship to art was intertwined with my relationship to my family. But that relationship was extremely dysfunctional and abusive," they say.

Behind closed doors, this control took a more stifling turn: they were barred from the sports they loved and coerced into a rigid, performative femininity. Until their drag mother helped them break out of it. Through rigorous mentorship – providing support and helping them decode their artistic persona – Divgikar tackled Gawde's fears regarding self-expression and public performance.

Kitty Su and Kinnar Samaj

One of the earliest scaffoldings for drag houses was erected at the nightclub where Gawde met Divgikar. Kitty Su, founded by Keshav Suri, the executive director of Lalit Suri Hospitality, in 2011, gave India's nascent drag scene its first real room to breathe. Divgikar is unequivocal about the debt. "Keshav was the first to introduce this sorority to us. This was a time when nobody else was doing queer-exclusive events." Even though Suri didn't create a formal house in his name, he made an incubator for the likes of Divgikar.

Suri views drag as a vital bridge into LGBTQIA+ politics, offering an accessible entry point for those unfamiliar with queer identities. He believes "drag has always been mainstream in spirit; the world is simply catching up to its sparkle [now]". He would love to see drag become far more expansive and inclusive. "Drag can be comedy, poetry, classical dance, ballet, music, or even political satire. Long before reality TV discovered it, India had drag thriving in folk theatre and *nukkad natak*s. If anything, we should be bringing drag back to the streets and stages where it has always belonged," he says.

Divgikar, who made history in 2020 as the first Indian drag performer on the Forbes 30 Under 30 Asia list, is a drag multi-hyphenate. "I come from privilege. I am formally educated, and I was never forced to leave my home," she says. Over the years, Divgikar, with her signature long brown hair and chunky bling, has broken mainstream barriers by competing on shows such as *Sa Re Ga Ma Pa*, and appearing in film and television productions such as *Thank You for Coming* (2023) and *36 Days* (2024).

CONTINUED ON
» PAGE 4



Stories in the wind Tourists zip through Fontainhas, the oldest Latin quarter of Panjim, Goa. (GETTY IMAGES)

Stanley Carvalho

The Portuguese may have departed after more than four centuries of colonial rule, but Goa today finds itself under a different and more insidious form of occupation. Economic colonialism – driven by outsiders armed with massive buying power, political patronage and cultural indifference – has begun to displace local communities, monopolise resources and steadily reshape the state’s identity. What is at stake is not merely land or livelihood, but the very idea of Goa itself.

It is against this backdrop that *Appetite*, a new anthology of stories, essays and poems, positions itself. Distressed by the transformation of their homeland into a commodity, Goans continue to push back, seeking an authentic sovereignty over land, ecology and culture, one that privileges community over commerce. This collection, edited by Shivrangana Rathore and Tino De Sa, attempts to capture that struggle by looking beyond postcard tourism and sun-soaked clichés to reveal a more complex, unsettled Goa.

Composed around the central metaphor of appetite, the book gathers the work of members of The Goa Writers – those who live or have lived in Goa. *Appetite* here is not restricted to hunger or consumption; as one story suggests, it also means to seek, reach, beseech. It becomes a way of engaging with a place in constant flux, provoking debates around belonging, settlement and identity.

Varied narratives

The fiction section is rooted in the local milieu. Clyde D’Souza’s opening story, ‘Sorpotel’, is a darkly comic yet unsettling portrait of simmering sibling rivalries. What begins as a convivial gathering over beer and *sorpotel* (Goan pork delicacy) spirals into something dire.

Michelle Mendonca

GOA, DESIRED AND DISPUTED

A new anthology of stories, essays and poems attempts to look beyond clichés, to provoke debates around belonging, settlement and identity

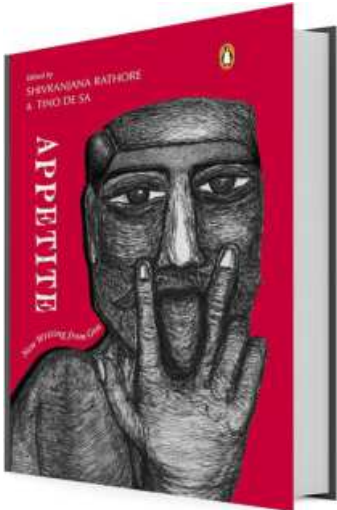
Bambawale’s ‘The Real Housewives of Assagao’ lampoons the entitled returnees: women who live in Delhi or abroad, who descend upon their second homes in Goa and pontificate on fashion, travel and local governance, oblivious to the lives unfolding around them.

Land, inevitably, emerges as a persistent issue. Pamela D’Mello’s ‘A Morning with God’ examines the misuse of the Mundkar Act – legislation originally intended to protect tenants and tillers but often weaponised to facilitate land grabs.

One of the anthology’s quiet triumphs is ‘The Cream of the Milk’ by celebrated Konkani writer Damodar Mauzo, the only translated piece in the book. Tender and humane, it reminds readers of the centrality of Konkani to Goan identity and the importance of translation. One wishes there had been more such inclusions to deepen the anthology’s linguistic authenticity.

Meghana Karanjkar’s ‘Paying Guest’ is a chilling departure in tone, a grim look at the dark side of Goa’s idyllic image where unsuspecting migrants get swindled.

The poetry section acts as a welcome interlude between



Appetite: New Writing from Goa
Ed. Shivrangana Rathore & Tino De Sa
Ebury Press
₹499

narratives. The six poems range from political unease to intimate praise of a lover and her mother, to an affectionate nod to Vikram Seth’s *The Golden Gate*.

Sip it like feni

The essays provide the anthology’s most wide-ranging reflections, probing Goa’s past and present through appetites for food, writing, love, hobbies and

even hate. Victor Rangel-Ribeiro’s ‘An Appetite for the Writing Life, Without End’ is a candid and inspiring opener, tracing a centenarian writer’s lifelong devotion to the craft. Heta Pandit’s ‘An Appetite for Memories’ follows, evoking food as an archive of personal and cultural history.

Alisha D’Souza’s forthright essay on matchmaking and marriage in Goa is laced with puckish humour, while Pragya Bhagat offers a comical take on dating apps and modern romance. Frederick Noronha tackles a perennial taboo in ‘Why is Sex a Four-Letter Word in India?’

One of the more revelatory essays is Edith Noronha Melo Furtado’s ‘Craving for the Chic’ which explores France’s largely forgotten cultural influence on Goa – an influence that faded after liberation. Mehru Jaffer’s ‘Such Hunger for Hate’ strikes a darker, political note, lamenting how intolerance and violence are eroding the country’s moral core.

Amid the insider-outsider debate, Seema Mustafa offers a pragmatic appeal in ‘The Wannabe Colonizers or Some Such’ – that newcomers must learn the language, respect social norms and embrace the Goan way of life.

The anthology closes with Hune Margulies’ reflective ‘A Meditation on Appetite for Goa’, a fitting finale that circles back to migration, identity and authenticity, asking searching questions about what truly constitutes Goan culture.

Appetite is a breezy yet layered read; creative, vibrant and alert to the present moment with fresh perspectives on Goa. At a time when India is grappling with issues such as identity and cultural changes, the anthology is timely. Like Goa’s beloved *feni*, it demands to be savoured slowly, not consumed hastily and greedily.

The reviewer is a Bengaluru-based independent journalist.

A portrait or a parable?

This book may divide readers, depending on what they seek from fiction

Abdullah Khan

When a book arrives with so much praise, you pick it up expecting something unusual. Allen Levi’s *Theo of Golden* carries that pressure of being called a special book from the very first page.

The central idea is interesting. It is not exactly out of the box, but it draws you in. Theo, an old man from New York, arrives alone in Golden, a peaceful Southern town in America where no one knows him. At a café, he notices a wall filled with pencil portraits, drawn with great skill by a local artist. Those faces stay with him. What begins as curiosity turns into a personal mission: he buys the portraits one by one, tracks down the people in them, and returns each drawing.

Through this routine, he gradually enters the lives of Golden’s residents. Nothing dramatic happens. He sits across from them and listens. There is an old painter, a confused young student, a bookseller, a prosecutor and his wife, a dignified street musician, and a father troubled by his child’s suffering.

While he listens to their stories, Theo speaks little about himself. In a small town, such silence invites doubt. People wonder who he is, why he has come, and what he seeks. At first, there is hesitation. But his manner is plain. He asks for nothing. Slowly, he earns people’s trust.

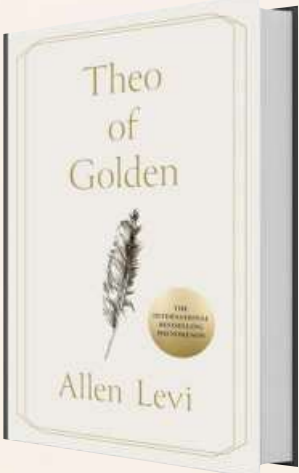
Meanwhile, the city of Golden comes alive in the narrative. Its streets, buildings, roads and markets are described in visible detail, giving the setting a presence of its own.

Resolution sans friction

Despite the careful build-up, however, the promise the novel makes in the initial pages does not fully come through.

The narrative follows a predictable pattern: Theo selects a portrait, finds the person, listens, says a few thoughtful words, and moves on. The pace remains slow, shaped by memory and reflection.

This same calmness defines Theo himself. He remains gentle and



Theo of Golden
Allen Levi
HarperCollins UK
₹599

composed throughout. At times, he feels less like a man of flesh and doubt and more like a figure meant to stand for something. Fiction needs imperfection. Here, those rough edges are rare.

A similar smoothness affects the supporting characters. They carry their own struggles, such as strained marriages and private grief, but their confessions come too easily. Strangers reveal everything in a single sitting. In life, disclosure comes in fragments. When resolution comes without friction, it feels arranged.

As the novel moves ahead, spiritual themes grow stronger: faith, forgiveness and what lies beyond this world. The tone inches closer to that of a parable. At times, it sounds didactic, like a self-help book.

Levi writes well for the most part. But at times, emotions are explained rather than allowed to surface on their own. The structure feels relaxed; a firmer edit might have strengthened the narrative.

In the end, this book will divide opinion. Some will value its faith in human decency. Others may want more conflict. It offers comfort, and whether that works depends on what you seek from fiction.

The reviewer is the author of *Patna Blues* and *A Man from Motihari*.



GETTY IMAGES

Blood in the boondocks

A murder mystery with a cluster of small reveals working up to the big one

Sheila Kumar

In her debut work of fiction, Roopa Unnikrishnan crafts an interesting murder mystery, positioning it in the early 1960s and setting it in a deceptively ordinary small town. Of course, what we see is not what we get, and the place in Tamil Nadu is a cauldron teeming with age-old taboos, seething communal tensions, secrets and lies, dirty deeds done in the dark, all waiting for that lit matchstick to go off.

Into this potential maelstrom arrive two Malayalis: the new Assistant Superintendent of Police, Jayan, and his whip-smart bride of 40 days, Uma. The couple hasn’t settled in before the first of a series

of calamitous events fetches up at their doorstep literally– a man carrying the severed head of his wife. It soon transpires that Vikraman has decapitated his wife himself, singing the old infidelity tune.

Soon, incidents break out like a rash all over Manamadurai; a robbery at a bank manager’s house, another at the local *zamindar*’s mansion, a second decapitated body, this time of an unidentified male.

Running simultaneously to this trail is Uma’s exploration of the place, its Ladies Club members, the town’s two medical men. The ‘jasmine murders’ of the title hints at a fragrant surface with a murky undertow. Both trails meet, of course, and end up with Uma being



Author Roopa Unnikrishnan (ROOPAONLINE.COM)

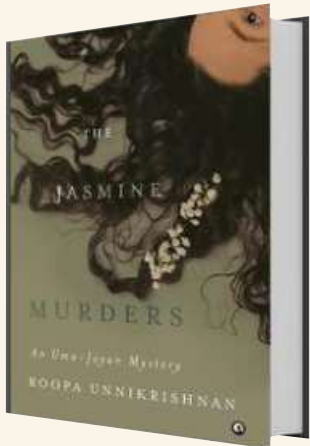
of immense help to her policeman husband.

This is a murder mystery which does not pepper the plot with red herrings, and neither does it get the reader guessing as the story unspools quite organically. Here, we are presented with a series of incidents, a bunch of small reveals working up to the big one, and all

we have to do is follow the prominent dots.

Inspired by parents

The denouement is as dramatic as it gets, with Jayan’s chase of the perpetrator leading him to Dhanushkodi just as a cyclone hits the place, leaving death and devastation in its watery wake.



The Jasmine Murders
Roopa Unnikrishnan
Aleph
₹799

her husband soon gets used to his new wife’s assertive ways. The author has said in interviews that the story is partly inspired by her parents’ life.

Despite being a promising debut, the book reads like a first draft at times. A gruesome package is placed on a table and the sentence ends with a mention of the damp thud it makes against the floor. Somebody gestures at a locked metal almirah... only, they are sitting in a Jeep at the time. A character tells himself he needs some strong coffee to get him through the day and the next minute, is found drinking tea.

The dynamic between Uma and her mother, too, is not explored deeply and is resolved in a rather pat fashion. It’s the same with Uma and her brood of elder brothers; the reader isn’t sure if they bullied her or if she ruled over them.

The reviewer is an author, journalist and manuscript editor based in Bengaluru.



GETTY IMAGES

Only the dead for company

A memoir that offers a moving study of quiet heroism thriving on the extreme edges of society

Navamy Sudhish
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The essence of the memoir, *The Corpse Collector: A True Story*, can be distilled into two defining moments. The first is a poignant scene where a 15-year-old schoolboy wades through the mighty Periyar river to retrieve the decaying body of a dear friend. The narration is so raw that the wetness of the water, the putrid smell of the corpse, and the boy’s anguish are almost palpable. This first encounter with death becomes a turning point that charts the course of Vinu P.’s life. He finds purpose in serving the dead, assisting the police with victims of unnatural deaths, and eventually embracing his identity as a “corpse collector.”

The second scene illustrates the devastating social cost of this calling. While attending a relative’s wedding, Vinu joins the guests for the *sadya* (feast). He sits before a plantain leaf topped with rice and curries, but just as he is about to eat, he is asked to leave. His eyes well up at the crushing humiliation of being shunned by his own people, and he walks out. Together, these incidents capture the core of his story: the visceral reality of his work as a professional corpse handler and the status of a social pariah that it inevitably brings him.

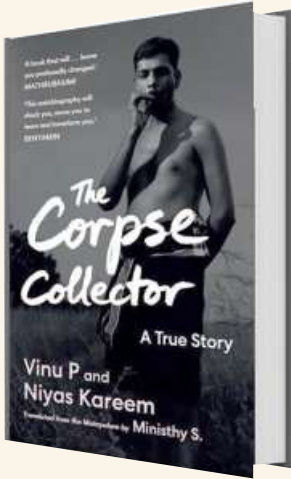
Written by Vinu P. and Niyas Kareem, and translated sensitively by Ministhy S., the book transcends the grim documentation of death, becoming an exploration of how we define humanity. The narrative follows Vinu’s journey through the most harrowing environments – recovering bodies from railway tracks, wading through faeces-filled canals, and crawling through claustrophobic pipelines. For Vinu, this is far more than a vocation; he performs his duties with meticulous care and veneration.

Whether he is retrieving a semi-decomposed body from water or carefully lowering a hanging corpse, Vinu eschews clinical “techniques.” Instead, he simply hugs the body with quiet reverence, ensuring the fragile, decaying remains do not detach or suffer further indignity. Over 25 years, he has recovered thousands of bodies for the police and buried unclaimed ones using his own limited resources, driven by a steadfast belief that the dead deserve respect.

Yet, his life is defined by solitude and sorrow. Despite providing an essential service,

Vinu is shunned with the same hostility reserved for a rabid animal. His social isolation is so severe that, denied the company of the living, he begins to seek solace in the most unexpected, heartbreaking ways. His story is a searing portrait of a man who offers the ultimate dignity to the dead, only to be denied basic humanity by the living.

The Corpse Collector is also a tribute to Vinu’s *asanmar* (masters) – a band of elderly mentors who exist on the extreme fringes of society. These senior corpse collectors camp under overbridges with almost no belongings, remaining perpetually inebriated and speaking in a string of expletives, fully accustomed to their status as outcasts. Their lives often end in profound loneliness.



The Corpse Collector
Vinu P. and Niyas Kareem
Juggernaut
₹699

It is against this backdrop of abandonment that Vinu shares his ultimate dream; it serves as a heartbreaking testament to his yearning to grant the forgotten a peaceful, dignified rest.

However, Vinu’s life is not entirely defined by shadows; light enters in the form of a nursing assistant, Bincy. Some policemen treat him with affection and compassion. Vinu’s statement that “the Kerala Police is my greatest support and succour” is born from a rare, unblemished bond with the authorities. There are also unexpected acts of grace – an elderly woman in Canada sends financial aid and an eatery owner prioritises feeding Vinu over the risk of losing prejudiced patrons.

The Corpse Collector stands as a moving portrait of quiet heroism thriving on the extreme edges of society. It is a stark reminder that the truest form of compassion is that which is extended to those who can no longer ask for it, and from whom nothing can be gained in return.

INTERVIEW

DNA OF AUTHORITARIANISM

Journalist Anne Applebaum has chronicled the rise of populist and autocratic regimes worldwide

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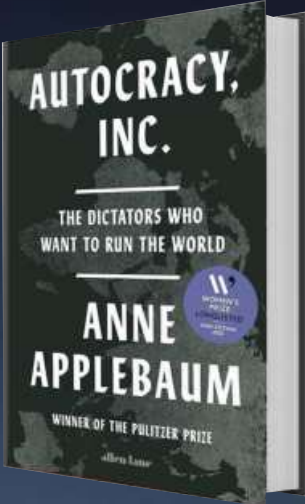
After a series of books on the rise of communism in Russia, journalist Anne Applebaum is chronicling the rise of populism and how even democratically elected governments are turning authoritarian worldwide. In her recent works, *Twilight of Democracy: The Failure of Politics and the Parting of Friends* (Penguin); her introduction to Hannah Arendt’s seminal work, *The Origins of Totalitarianism* (Penguin); and last year’s *Autocracy, Inc.: The Dictators Who Want to Run the World* (Allen Lane, Penguin), Applebaum has tried to draw common threads between regimes, trace the rise of kleptocracies, technological controls, and the cooperation networks between countries. Applebaum, who lives in Poland and is married to Polish Foreign Minister Radoslaw Sikorski, has often been accused of a pro-Western bias. She focuses her critiques on countries aligned with Russia and China rather than on the U.S. and Europe. A trenchant critic of U.S. President Donald Trump in her regular column at *The Atlantic*, Applebaum says in this interview on Zoom that she studies authoritarian behaviours rather than seeking to classify countries. Edited excerpts:

Question: Is the world turning more autocratic and authoritarian?
Answer: Yes, it feels like that right now, because of changes in the U.S., Russia, China, and elsewhere. But I would urge everyone to remember that nothing about history is inevitable — what happens tomorrow depends on what we do today. If you look back even on the history of the last 20-30 years, there are a lot of inflection points when things could have gone differently. [Former Russian President] Boris Yeltsin might have chosen a different leader [than Vladimir Putin]. He almost chose Boris Nemtsov, who would have led Russia in a different direction. [In the U.S., Democrat] Hillary Clinton came very close to winning the election in 2016. She, in fact, won the most number of individual votes. [If she had won,] that would have set the U.S. in a different direction. There is a lot about the current moment that is accidental or has happened through random coincidences. Things could go in another direction. So I don’t want people to think that they should give up

and not continue to think about creating a better and more just world.

Q: Tell us about *Autocracy, Inc.*
A: The book was an attempt to explain the relationship between countries that don’t have the same ideology, but were nevertheless assisting one another and helping one another stay in power, such as Russia, China, Iran, North Korea and, until recently, Venezuela. These countries were sharing surveillance technology. They were watching one another to learn how to control their populations. For example, in Ukraine, Iranian drones and North Korean troops are fighting on the side of the Russians. Chinese technology is also supporting the Russian war effort. Together, they create a common authoritarian narrative: the idea that autocracies are stable and safe, while democracies are weak and divided. They are seeking to defeat the ideas of their internal political opposition, who almost always use the language of rights, rule of law, democracy, freedom, and transparency. To do this, they push back against those ideas wherever they appear — within their own countries and abroad.

Q: Many would say the names you give are essentially from a Western prism. How do



you stratify each of these countries that you write about?

A: I don’t like to classify countries. I like to talk about authoritarian behaviours and practices. And those behaviours and practices are pushing back against the rule of law. When courts make decisions not based on the law or the Constitution, but because those in power tell them what to decide, this is an authoritarian practice. You can find this in China, Russia, and in some American states.

Another authoritarian practice is the secretive stealing, hiding,

and transferring of money around the world, often using offshore accounts and anonymous shell companies. That is a practice you can find in the U.S. as well.

I am not making a judgment about this or that country; I am saying that these are the practices and the countries that use them the most are beginning to work together. The Chinese government has a fully controlled Internet. In Russia, [foreign] apps and platforms are cut off, and state propaganda is a way of marginalising and excluding anybody who has different views. These are practices you can also see in democracies; autocratic practices are available everywhere. I don’t think it is particularly Western or non-Western to talk about them. I see them in the U.S. and I see them in China.

Q: A lot of these leaders and regimes are popular...

A: You have to ask what popular means in a society where there are no alternatives, no public sphere, and no real debate. For example, it is illegal in Russia to criticise the war. In the beginning of the war in Ukraine, you had to talk about it as a special military operation. If it is illegal to speak about it and people are arrested for speaking about it in public, [then] when a pollster calls up a taxi driver in Krasnoyarsk and says, “Hello, I’m calling from Moscow, what do you think of the President?,” what do you expect the driver to say? He is going to say, “I’m in favour of him”. “What do you think of the war?” “Of course, I support it.”

The goal of illiberal leaders is to move in the direction where people are more and more afraid to criticise the regime or the government, where technically the apparatus of democracy might be there, but in practice, it is very difficult for anyone to say what they think or for any opposition leaders to emerge. There is a whole scale and spectrum of different countries with different systems, but be careful with the word popularity in places where the media is controlled and where people are afraid.

Author Anne Applebaum (GETTY IMAGES)



Scan the QR code to listen to Anne Applebaum in conversation on magazine.thehindu.com

BROWSER

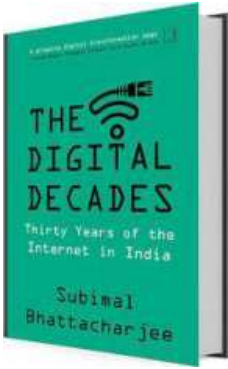
A Historian in Gaza

Jean-Pierre Filiu
Context/Westland
₹499
This eyewitness account of Jean-Pierre Filiu narrates the 33 days he spent in Gaza. The French historian and professor at Sciences Po University has also been a recipient of the Middle East Monitor’s Palestine Book Award for his 2015 book, *Gaza: A History*.



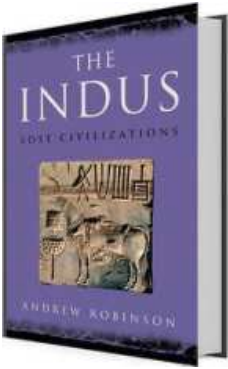
The Digital Decades: Thirty Years of the Internet in India

Subimal Bhattacharjee
Simon and Schuster
₹699
An independent cybersecurity adviser and consultant, Bhattacharjee traces India’s internet journey from its 1995 launch through the dot-com era, the mobile revolution, and into today’s Digital India vision.



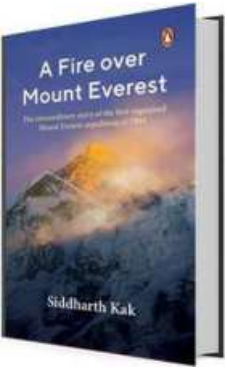
The Indus

Andrew Robinson
PanMacmillan
₹399
Robinson, who has written more than 25 books across subjects, shines a light on the legacy of the Indus Valley civilisation in modern India and Pakistan. An accessible introduction to a culture marked by technological, economic and artistic vigour.



A Fire Over Mount Everest

Siddharth Kak
Penguin
₹499
India’s 1984 Everest expedition remains historic. It witnessed Bachendri Pal becoming the first Indian woman to reach the summit. In this book, documentary maker Kak revisits the climb, its struggles, rivalries, and environmental strain.



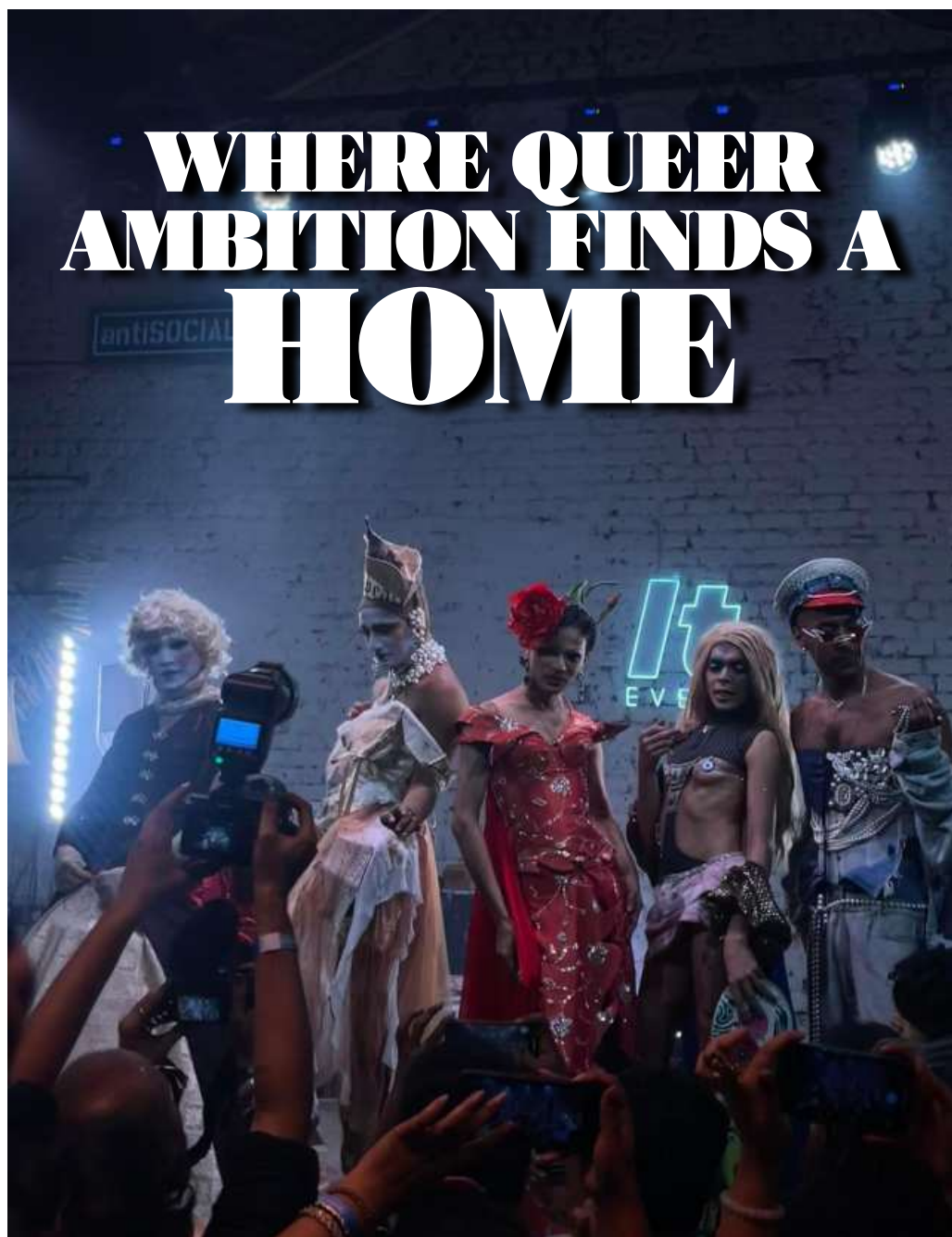
CONTINUED FROM
» PAGE 1

As she found her footing in the entertainment industry, she saw how other drag artists had talent that “needed polishing”. So, when she decided to build her own house, Divgikar turned to the grassroots for guidance. “I looked at the *gharana* culture and Hijra community, and realised that what they’ve been doing for so long – with community building and self-organising – is amazing,” she says.

Divgikar has 18 elders from the (Hijra) Kinnar Samaj who counsel transgender communities across the country. As her house grew, she went on to mentor the likes of Delhi-based designer and artist Anvesh Sahoo, and Mumbai-based model and drag performer Suruj (Glorious Luna).

Luna, with her arched pencil-thin eyebrows and lavish handcrafted ensembles, has since started her own house in 2021.

“Being a drag mother is a little different from what many would expect. I sit with my children and brainstorm creative ideas. We cook together while discussing our blocks, or plan for a future project while dancing to a new hit number,” explains Luna. In a house, there is room for everyone. “We make things happen together. These hangouts might look casual, but they give birth to big things.” With her children, who often live together, Luna has gone on to create the country’s premier drag event, the It Ball, and a queer modelling agency, Current Management, to create opportunities for marginalised talent.



Letting children fly
Sahoo first met Divgikar when she judged ‘Mr Gay India 2016’ (which he won). He credits her house for making him feel like he truly belonged. “When I entered the world of KōHEnur, it felt like a parallel universe where we were all queer, were able to talk freely about our experiences, and were

empowered to manifest our dreams,” he says. Though Sahoo’s biological family wasn’t unsupportive, a chosen family offered an oasis he couldn’t find at home. “With my parents, I lived a milkqu Coast life,” he says. “So, I cherished that balance. Having my drag family where I could give and receive support

without any apology.” Divgikar has watched drag children join, grow and leave, and held space for all of it. “I’m not one of those mothers who will say, ‘How can you stop doing drag?’ It’s a journey, and understanding that drag is not for you is also a part of it.” Every three years or so, the structure of a drag



(Clockwise from left) Glorious Luna with filmmaker Pratul Narang; Gautam Bhandokar as Mystical Flame; and performers at the It Ball. (SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT)



Every time we’re in drag, we’re advocating for our rights. Performing is resistance for us, and it ultimately helps everyone to not be tied up with the dos and don’ts of gender and sexuality

GLORIOUS LUNA
Drag mother and activist



family changes, she adds. Drag children go on to found their own houses, or build their own community outside the house; they also leave to pursue other, often related, career paths. “It can be hard

and lives of their own, but the group chat remains active. “We keep coming back to each other when required,” they say.

Architecture of queer care

The care and acceptance of drag houses can often make the difference between surviving and living. Bengaluru-based actor and drag artist Alex Mathew, known by the avatar Maya, has experienced it first-hand. He met his drag mother, Boston-based queen LaWhore Vagistan (Kareem Khubchandani, a researcher and performance artist), while she was visiting India. Vagistan became a pivotal force in changing the trajectory of his career: teaching Mathew the art of storytelling “beyond dancing and singing”, and even how to do cut-crease makeup on his eyes.

But it was encountering a trans *gharana* in Andhra Pradesh a few years ago – while he worked for Solidarity Foundation, an NGO for sex workers and gender and sexual minorities in South India – that changed how Mathew understood the community altogether. “I met the head mother, Laila, and I performed ‘Kajra Re’ for her. She said, ‘Your expressions are so great that I would like to adopt you as my daughter,’” he says. “You can imagine how open the system is. She had known me for only a day.” Though he declined, he accepted what was truly an offer. “I told her all I need is your blessing. And she said, ‘That’s always there with you.’”

The Mumbai-based writer, artist and editor reports on fashion and culture.

Nahla Nainar
nahla.nainar@thehindu.co.in

Achyut Palav, 66, the Mumbai-based Marathi master calligrapher who was honoured with the Padma Shri in 2025, recalls the day when his Class VIII teacher assigned him the task of writing “Thought for the day” on the blackboard. Little did he know that it would lead him to a career in typography and letters.

Palav is credited with the creation of ‘Mukta Lipi’, an amalgamation of Modi and Devanagari scripts. His ‘Calligraphy Roadways’ project in 2024 introduced young students from more than 20 Indian colleges to calligraphy as an art form. “Calligraphy teaches patience and concentration. One has to be very aware of one’s stance and space when writing. And the beauty of calligraphy is that it makes even a simple word or phrase look like a masterpiece,” says the founder of Navi Mumbai’s Achyut Palav School of Calligraphy.

The good old days

Said to have been seen in ancient scripts such as Brahmi and Kharosthi, Indian calligraphy today encompasses the vast linguistic heritage of the nation. Regional scripts like Bengali, Tamil and Telugu used calligraphy from 6th-16th centuries, while from the 8th-12th centuries, Arabic and Persian calligraphy blended with Indian styles to create a vast ocean of literary and artistic works.

There was a time when India’s popular culture and artistic sensibilities were shaped by multilingual calligraphy – for instance, in Urdu, which

adapted from the Arabic script. Indian film posters (Alam Ara, 1931; *Mughal-e-Azam*, 1960; *Pakeezah*, 1972), wedding cards, shop hearings and even legal documents were handwritten/hand-painted in Urdu, as were a number of magazines (*Shama*, *Din Dunia*) and newspapers (*The Muslim*, printed in Chennai) that set the foundation of a booming publishing industry.

The once-ubiquitous calligraphy became outmoded with the advent of digitalisation and desktop



INK BEYOND SCRIPTURE

Arabic calligraphy is making a revival as an art form in South India, steered by women and social media

publishing in the early 1990s in India. These years,

however, have seen a renewed interest as artists are being drawn to Arabic calligraphy’s retro appeal, beyond its assimilation in regional language scripts (Arabi-Malayalam, Arwi) and religious texts (the *Quran*). Its cultural resurgence in South India is being steered by a small group of artist-revivalists. If Doha-based Malayali artist-designer Abdul Kareem creates calligraphi (graffiti with Arabic calligraphy), at a South Korean exhibition last year, Malayali calligrapher Narayana Bhattathiri became the first Indian to be appointed the World Calligraphy Association’s honorary



director. The recently formed Tamil Nadu Arabic Calligraphy (TNAC) Hub groups over 100 young people who are engaged in the art.

Space to learn and grow

At Tiruchi’s Jamal Mohamed College, heads are bowed as a group of women students of the Urdu department practise the art of *khat* (Arabic calligraphy). TNAC Hub founder Aashifa Banu shows them how to write the first Arabic letter *alif* using the *qalam* (bamboo pen). “Since TNAC began, over 120 women and 80 men have joined our platform,” says Banu, who runs a calligraphy-based craft business in Pollachi and conducts online classes.

Social media has fuelled “a growing interest in calligraphy among young people”, says

Coimbatore-based calligrapher Faiz Qadiri, who is mentoring the TNAC Hub team. “I always advise my students to learn both streams: study the six Arabic classical

fonts *nashk*, *thuluth*, *muhawraq*, *rayhani*, *tawqi*, and *riqaq*; and learn calligraphy as a freehand art,” he adds.

Kochi-based Jasila Jafar, who specialises in the classical *thuluth* and *nashk* scripts, says, “Islamic calligraphy has evolved continuously over centuries, and women have always been part of its development – even if their contributions were not always fully documented.” Jafar runs the Nisa ul Khat project, an online community dedicated to women calligraphers, which has more than 100 members from India and abroad. “We want to spread awareness about Arabic calligraphy, its artistic depth, historical roots, and spiritual significance – while creating a supportive space for women to learn and grow together,” she says.

Into the fold

For over 30 years, Hyderabad-based Anil Kumar Chawhan, 56, has painted Quranic verses on the walls of around 200 mosques and *dargahs* in Andhra Pradesh, Karnataka and Maharashtra. “I began painting Urdu signboards in Hyderabad, even

Different strokes (Clockwise from far left) Anil Kumar Chawhan; TNAC Hub members; Achyut Palav with his calligraphy artwork. (NAGARA GOPAL, R. VENKATESH, SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT)



though I didn’t know the language. People would write it out for me on paper, and I’d just replicate the letters on the boards. Gradually, I became interested in Urdu and Arabic calligraphy, and began to understand what I was painting. I also started dabbling in Urdu poetry after learning calligraphy,” he says.

As he reads out the verses he painted on the walls of the historic Shahamat Jung mosque, Chawhan says his journey as a non-Muslim artist commissioned to work in Islamic buildings wasn’t an easy one. A decree by Hyderabad’s Jamia Nazamia university allowed him to work so long as he respects the shrines’ sanctity and keeps himself clean by performing the *wudu* ablutions. Assisted by his younger brother, Chawhan travels to calligraphy assignments around India, and wants “to traverse the world with this skill that has given me so much”, he says.

Meanwhile, Tiruchi’s Jamal Mohamed College’s Computerised Calligraphy Training Centre is teaching students multilingual desktop publishing. It is one of four centres in Tamil Nadu offering certificate courses in Arabic and Urdu digital typing, skills that will help promote calligraphy to Gen Next.

Scan the QR code to watch Arabic calligraphy revival in South India on magazine.thehindu.com

GREEN HUMOUR

Rohan Chakravarty



How the Northeast State is trying to destigmatise sexual health conversations with a new café

BREWING COURAGE IN MIZORAM



has the country’s highest HIV prevalence, currently at 2.75% of the population, according to the India HIV Estimate 2025 technical report.

Between April 2025 and January 2026, Mizoram recorded 1,478 new cases – 955 men and 523 women, including 86 pregnant women. “What is especially worrying is that the majority of people testing positive are in their most productive years,” says Dr. Jane Rinsang Ralte, Project Director, MSACS.

The situation has been compounded by the influx of cheap drugs from across the porous border with Myanmar, part of Southeast Asia’s drug-producing Golden Triangle; abysmally low condom use; and ‘serial monogamy’, where multiple monogamous relationships over a lifetime increase the risk of HIV transmission.

The epidemic was once driven

almost entirely by intravenous drug use. That has now fallen to around 27%. Nearly 70% of new cases are attributed to sexual transmission.

Shows out, humans in
It is against this grim backdrop that SPOT has emerged as a first-of-its-kind, people-centred health initiative, created through a partnership between MSACS and AHF India Cares, the India programme of AIDS Healthcare Foundation, a U.S.-based non-profit. SPOT is not a clinic trying to mimic a café, but a social hub meant to normalise conversations and care around sexual health and sexually transmitted infections (STIs).

“In a State where adult HIV prevalence is almost 13 times the national average, we need to look beyond individualism,” says Lalrinpui, Health and Family Welfare Minister of Mizoram. For services to outpace stigma, the

minister believes innovation must become the cornerstone of public health, and clinical outcomes must be delivered with dignity.

“New models like SPOT, aligned with rights-based national and international principles and frameworks, bridge the gaps left by conventional systems. Our goal is to scale up such cafés across Mizoram,” adds Lalrinpui.

Prevention can work only when young people don’t feel reduced to a statistic. “SPOT meets young people where they already belong – socially, emotionally, culturally – to help them own their health with confidence and dignity,” says Dr. V. Sam Prasad, Country Programme Director, AHF India Cares. “For young adults in Mizoram, this can make all the difference between meaningful engagement and being left behind.”

The café thus becomes more than just a setting. “Coming out of the closet is critical to replacing



stigma with empathy,” says Henry Zodinliana Pachau, Professor of Social Work at Mizoram University and co-author of several national and global studies on HIV/AIDS and STIs in Mizoram. “Amid the State’s booming café culture, SPOT provides the perfect push for young people to not only talk freely about STIs but also benefit from crucial guidance on healthy behaviours and harm reduction services.”

The name SPOT was deliberate. “In the Mizo language, ‘spot’ is



New models like SPOT, aligned with rights-based national and international principles and frameworks, bridge the gaps left by conventional systems. Our goal is to scale up such cafés across Mizoram

LALRINPUI
Health and Family Welfare Minister, Mizoram

slang for illicit places where people go to drink or use drugs,” explains Dr. Ralte. “We wanted to change that negative connotation.”

In the few weeks since it opened, SPOT has welcomed dozens of youngsters, one as young as 10, who come after school or college, between work shifts, during dates, or while hanging out with friends.

They seek life-critical answers, mental health support, relationship advice and free condoms – all over a cuppa in a discreet environment, unburdened by tedious appointments and explanations. Like in real life, curiosity is often how it begins. The 10-year-old, for example, visiting with her parents, wanted to understand how SPOT could help children her age deal with stress and confusion.

All heart, no judgment
“To me, SPOT feels like the safe space I didn’t have when I first discovered I was HIV-positive,” says Vanlalruati Colney, activist and founder of Positive Women’s Network of Mizoram. She was one of the earliest Mizo women to publicly disclose her HIV-positive status in 2003. “SPOT humanises the challenges that ignorance and affliction throw at young people. This is what the battle against HIV/AIDS needs – compassion, courage and care without judgment.”

SPOT has good company in a city devising new ways to puncture the shroud of reticence, such as a massive 30-ft. condom billboard – Aizawl’s first – and the unique ‘Love Brigade 2.0’ campaign, where two-wheeler taxi riders, wearing condom jackets, distribute free protection. Yet, Dr. Ralte says, it was hard to find a place for SPOT. “We wanted a central location, but most people were hesitant to rent us the space. Eventually, Lalantpui, owner of Aizawl Art Gallery, offered us a nearly 400 sq-ft. space below the gallery and the project became a reality with the support of MUP.”

SPOT will soon begin dual-kit HIV and syphilis testing, says Dr. Ralte. “There’s already growing demand to start blood tests as well.”

SPOT wants a positive diagnosis to become the beginning of care, not the end of hope. “We cannot force people away from certain actions, but we can definitely give them safer options,” concludes Dr. Ralte.

The writer is an independent journalist and commentator.



POP-A-RAZZI

Armed with memes

In a world spinning out of control, have funny videos and trends become our best coping strategy?

The Ugly American has long been a prototype – loud, boorish and insensitive to the culture of others. Now, Madhu Raju has become the epitome of the ‘Ugly Indian Abroad’ on the Internet.

Raju, an Indian-origin engineer in the U.S., went viral much to his own detriment when he made a dance reel with a woman at the World War II Memorial in Washington DC. The Internet slammed him for disrespecting the ambience of a war memorial, that too at a time when the U.S. is at war in Iran. Latest reports suggest Raju might be deported if he is found to have been making money from his dance studio in Dallas alongside his IT job, something not allowed on his H-1B visa.

At a time when the U.S. has been cracking down on immigrants, this seems like an act of provocation, both foolish and foolhardy, to disrespect the sanctity of a war memorial in one’s host country. But others dug out videos of Americans doing similar things

and asked whether the backlash on Raju wasn’t just racist. For example, two American brothers were arrested in Thailand in 2017 for deciding to take a butt selfie at the Wat Arun temple in Bangkok. In 2015, two American women were deported for taking nude photographs inside the Angkor Wat complex in Cambodia. At least Raju and his companion kept their clothes on.

Raju, who deleted his social media profiles, has not explained why he chose the War Memorial for his Reels but it’s hard to believe he could have been unaware of the significance of his locale. What’s actually more significant is he wasn’t just dancing. He was apparently doing something called the ‘Don’t Rush’ dance challenge on TikTok.

Living in a video game

The story isn’t really about the Ugly Indian Abroad. It’s about the desperation to go viral on social media. The War Memorial becomes just a

backdrop, nothing more. In fact, the more unlikely the backdrop, greater the chances of the video standing out from the pack and thus going viral. It’s social media’s version of shock and awe.

Recently, I went to Kolkata’s Alipore Museum, which used to be a jail. It features cells that housed freedom fighters like Subhas Chandra Bose, Jawaharlal Nehru and Bidhan Roy. It still has the gallows where the likes of Kanailal Dutta were hanged for killing an approver of the British. But the gallows had to be placed out of bounds from visitors because too many were sticking their heads in the noose and making funny videos.

We’re clearly live in a world where everything has become fodder for clickbait. As the Iran war erupted recently, I noticed a slew of memes poking fun at the happenings in West Asia, including the assassination of Iran’s supreme leader, Ayatollah Khamenei. At first, I was rather impressed at the alacrity with which people

came up with those memes. There have been Lego recreations of Khamenei’s compound being destroyed and Khamenei as an action figure. The White House itself posted videos using jokes from *Top Gun* and *Dragon Ball Z* with the caption ‘Wake up, Daddy’s home’ as if what’s happening in Iran is a video game rather than a war. But as they keep coming, it makes me wonder about the meme-ification of news.

Laughing at ourselves
One does not have to be a fan of the Ayatollah, but is the assassination of a top religious leader really the subject of memes? In a short attention span world, we do not have the time to read a real analysis of the implications of the attack on Iran, the tangled history of the U.S. meddling in Iranian affairs that led to the Ayatollahs coming to power in the first place, and the irony of the son of the late Shah of Iran being heralded as some kind harbinger of democracy when his father’s secret police was notorious for its brutal crushing of dissidents. But such analysis consumes time. A meme is timepass.

At one time, we complained that people did not want to read in-depth stories. News had to be compressed into a paragraph. Maybe, just into a headline. But now, news must be turned into a meme. Perhaps, that is the point. In a world that seems to be spinning out of control, the meme might be our coping strategy. We are not really laughing at what’s happening, but at our own helplessness.

As one popular meme shows – we are being encouraged to sip our soda with a paper straw to save the planet while global leaders seem to not care about kicking off World War III.

Sandip Roy is the author, most recently, of *Chapal Rani*, the Last Queen of Bengal.



PERSON OF INTEREST

SUNIL JAGLAN: IDEAS FOR AN EQUAL WORLD

This former *sarpanch* has a hundred ways to empower women, and men

Sunil Jaglan, 43, is evidence that the birth of a daughter can inspire a man to smash the patriarchy. His childhood home followed that classic Indian rule: housework is the woman's job.

"My father was a teacher but even on his holidays, he would be reading the newspaper as my mother served him," he says. "My habits were the same." Jaglan was waited hand on foot by his three younger sisters.

"We all studied but they also had to do housework and my work," he adds. "Wash my clothes, give me chai or I would say, 'I want to eat *namkeen chawal* [savoury rice]."

Now, he is a gender advocate with whom women share their most intimate problems. Jaglan is their window to a more equitable world and they discuss everything, from domestic violence and late periods

to vaginal health and hormonal imbalance.

It helps that he has great ideas, like his viral 2015 'Selfie With Daughter' campaign that urged proud fathers to take photographs with their daughters to fight female foeticide. He received 8 lakh images from around the world. That's only one of a 100 or so campaigns around gender equity that Jaglan has conjured up after his first daughter, Nandini, was born in 2012.

When he distributed sweets to celebrate her birth, he got sympathy and condolences. That was his Eureka moment. By then, the mathematics postgraduate was two years into his five-year stint as *sarpanch* (village leader) of the Bibipur Gram Panchayat in Haryana. That year, he organised a *khap mahapanchayat* in which women participated. They invited hundreds



of *khap* leaders to support them in a campaign against female foeticide. The State's sex ratio has climbed to 923 in 2025, from 850 in 2012.

The patriarchal virus
Many of Jaglan's early ideas focused on foeticide but later they expanded

to include issues such as 'Womaniya GDP', a campaign to compensate women for household chores or 'Gaali Bandh Ghar', an effort to prevent sexist abuses, and 'Women's Happiness Chart' that logged the number of hours in a day that women felt happy. "They are so

happy when there is a programme in the village, but they don't feel that same joy at home," he says.

Jaglan was trolled for his 2019 'Period Chart' campaign where he advocated pinning a chart that tracked a household's period cycles. Even before this, he had uploaded an image of himself holding a sanitary pad on social media. The Internet was aghast that a man was discussing such 'private' issues, but Jaglan couldn't care less. "In 2011, I bought a sanitary pad-making machine for the village but I couldn't talk about it," he says. "Now I can talk about this and more for 4-5 hours with anyone without hesitation."

After his *sarpanch* days, he turned consultant and continued his equal rights advocacy. He has been a professor of practice at two private universities in the region and, in 2017, he founded the non-profit Selfie With Daughter Foundation that has introduced his gender justice campaigns in 630 villages. He calls them 'Ehsaas (realisation) ka Software', to "kill the patriarchal virus".

Nandini, now 14, is an activist who petitions her principal about why teachers shouldn't segregate girls when talking about periods or how the 'no skirts, two braids' rule for Class IX students is illogical. Yashika, his younger daughter, wants people to celebrate 'Behen Dooj' alongside the traditional 'Bhai Dooj' that celebrates a sister's love and prayers for her brother's long life.

Breaking menopause silence
When Jaglan began discussing *rajonivritti* (menopause) with men in 2024, he found that 99% did not know about this key phase in the life of women. "Some didn't even know that periods stop," he says.

Jaglan says their first reaction was laughter, as they registered the freedom from birth control. But not one man had any idea what women go through or how to improve their quality of life.

"Men control the economics of the household and they don't allocate money for menopause consultations," he adds. That's when he began explaining to men how they could help the older women in their lives. In fact, many of his ideas in recent years target men.

When Jaglan launched a campaign to goad men to do more household work, he was logging 8-9 minutes of housework a day. "Now I'm at one hour plus," he says, listing all the things he does, such as cleaning the house/ toilets, making beds, doing laundry, folding clothes, shopping, getting his own water, tracking his children's health checkups and locking down the house.

He even has a modest repertoire of dishes he can cook, including *dal*, *khichdi* and *dalia*. His wife spends an hour and a half on housework against her previous three hours. "Gender equality can't be taught," says Jaglan. "It has to be lived."

Priya Ramani is a Bengaluru-based journalist and the co-founder of India Love Project on Instagram.

Bob Jones

The auction was routine. West, not wanting to lead either major suit after they had both been bid by the opponents, started off with a fourthbest two of clubs. South won in hand with the ace and led the king of diamonds. East took his ace and shifted to a low spade - four, nine, three. The defense continued spades until declarer won the third round with the ace in dummy. Hoping for three

GOREN BRIDGE

Good card reading

Both vulnerable, South deals

diamond tricks, South led a diamond to his nine, winning the trick and learning about the 4-1 split. West discarded a low heart. South took some time to consider what he knew.

West was presumed to have

started with four clubs and was known to have a singleton diamond. He was very likely to be 4-4 in the majors, meaning that the heart finesse probably would not work. He found a sequence of plays that was sure to be

NORTH
♠ A 8 6 3
♥ 3 2
♦ 10 5 4 3
♣ K J 6

WEST
♠ K Q 9 7
♥ Q 9 8 7
♦ 8
♣ 10 8 3 2

EAST
♠ J 5 2
♥ 10 5
♦ A J 7 6
♣ 9 7 5 4

SOUTH
♠ 10 4
♥ A K J 6 4
♦ K Q 9 2
♣ A Q

The bidding:
SOUTH 1♥
WEST Pass
NORTH 1♠
EAST Pass

2NT Pass 3NT All pass

Opening lead: Two of ♣

successful if West started with 4-4 in the major suits. He cashed the queen of diamonds, forcing a club discard from West, and led the queen of clubs. He overtook this with dummy's king and cashed

the jack of clubs. He exited with dummy's remaining spade to West, who had to lead a heart into declarer's ace. king, jack and South had his ninth trick. Very nicely played.

QUIZ

Easy like Sunday morning

History and its rulers



This city served as the capital of the Roman, Byzantine, Latin, and Ottoman empires. (GETTY IMAGES/ISTOCKPHOTO)

Berty Ashley

1 On March 15, 44 BCE, Roman senators assassinated a leader they feared would destroy the Republic. Ironically, the event ultimately collapsed it and paved the way for the rise of the Roman Empire. What historic event took place on this date?

2 Maria Ramolino had eight children, several of whom became rulers. Her second-eldest son crowned himself emperor

and placed many of his siblings on European thrones: Joseph (Spain), Jérôme (Westphalia), Louis (Holland), and Caroline (Naples). Who was he?

3 Despite ruling for only three-and-a-half years, this woman stabilised her kingdom after her brother's chaotic rule and became the only female ruler of the Delhi Sultanate. Who was she?

4 This city served as the capital of the Roman, Byzantine, Latin, and Ottoman empires, and was

Europe's largest and richest city for centuries. In 330 CE, a Roman emperor renamed it 'New Rome'. Which city is this?

5 Born Temujin and raised in poverty, he united the Mongol tribes and built the largest contiguous empire in history. By what name, meaning 'Universal Ruler', is he better known?

6 Historians believe the now-extinct North African elephant enabled a famous commander to attempt a daring route

during a war against Rome. Which historic military episode was this?

7 After showing unusual kindness to enemy soldiers during the Napoleonic Wars, French general Jean Bernadotte was invited to become crown prince of another nation in 1810 and later ruled as King Charles XIV from 1818. Which country did he rule?

8 Queen Lili'uokalani, the last sovereign ruler of a Pacific island kingdom, composed the

song 'Aloha 'Oe' before being overthrown and the islands annexed. Which archipelago did she rule?

9 The fourth king of this kingdom initiated a transition to democracy and abdicated before the first elections. Today, the country is known for measuring progress through Gross National Happiness. Which country is this?

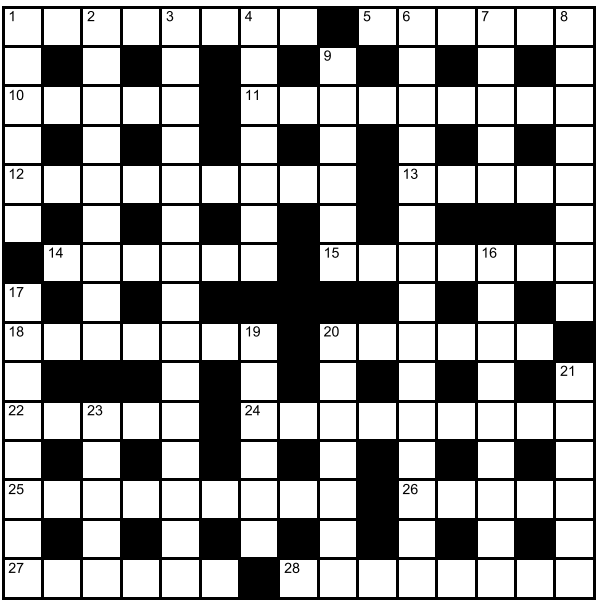
10 This ruler conquered territories from Eastern Europe to modern-day Pakistan, but died in Greece at just 32 years. His death without an heir led to the fragmentation of his empire. Who was he?

A molecular biologist from Madurai, our quizmaster enjoys trivia and music, and is working on a rock ballad called 'Coffee is a Drink, Kaapi is an Emotion.' @bertyashley

10. Alexander the Great
9. Bhutan
8. Hawaii
7. Sweden
6. Hannibal crossing the Alps
5. Genghis Khan
4. Constantinople
3. Razia Sultan
2. Napoleon Bonaparte
1. The assassination of Julius Caesar

Answers

THE HINDU SUNDAY CROSSWORD NO. 47 (Set by Afterdark)



Across
1 Strangely pa's upset with publication layout designs (5-3)
5 Tailors lack substance, cuff's right inside garment (1-5)
10 Speak with one heartless deserter to board (5)
11 Demented libel on revolt (9)
12 Put parsley on the sides, look at adding some dill as spice (5,4)
13 Doctor in Colorado has mega storage device (2-3)
14 Motto of rowdy? Bungle first in chaos (6)
15 Mythical character appearing in 'Prometheus and Manes' (7)
18 Judge collecting return gift from shed (7)
20 Vain lady pursues guy possessing intelligence as a rule (6)
22 Knight offers help to trap a water nymph (5)
24 Say, buttercup's ordeal with headache overcomes enthusiasm at the beginning (9)
25 Impenitent Usha steals new alto at Maine and departs (9)
26 Show gratitude to Chinese in deserted Tabuk (5)
27 Stories cover a new leader's protests (3-3)
28 English politician's new year party was heavenly (8)

Down
1 Application software consumes memory quick (6)
2 Alert son dismissed students, yelled angrily snatching instrument (5-4)
3 Often Newton and Hayden collaborate to

master short version (5,3,3,4)
4 Threaten Aden perhaps to dismiss the leader and disfigure (7)
6 Second felon lifted candy at regular intervals covertly and with aplomb (4-11)
7 As per sources, Indian climate interchanges erratically, result is getting colder (5)
8 10 people surround Earl's Tesla at apartment (8)
9 Sailor's poem on habitats (6)
16 Hector tore email and set right (9)
17 Calm & composed ritual with participation of hungry queen (8)
19 Eastern axis joins INC founder to resurrect (6)
20 Mother-in-law with first lady and mother forms a barrier (7)
21 Summon British national smuggling cut coke (6)
23 Idiotic leaders of India neither agree, nor engage (5)

SOLUTION NO. 46

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INDIA'S FORGOTTEN JEWELS

The Lisbon art historian on Usha Balakrishnan's new book that documents India's folk and tribal ornamental traditions

Hugo Miguel Crespo

The publication of Usha R. Balakrishnan's *Silver & Gold: Visions of Arcadia* is good news for art lovers and jewellery enthusiasts alike. Any new book by Balakrishnan merits close attention: she is arguably the most authoritative historian of Indian jewellery, having written or co-authored some of the field's most significant titles and exhibition catalogues. This includes *Dance of the Peacock: Jewellery Traditions of India* (1999), one of the most comprehensive works on the subject, alongside Oppi Untracht's 1997 seminal volume.

As chief curator of the World Diamond Museum, she edited *Diamonds Across Time: Facets of Mankind* (2020). Her research ranges from princely jewels, most notably those once owned by the Nizams of Hyderabad (acquired by the Indian government in 1995 and entrusted to her for study and documentation), to the creative

genius of contemporary jewellers and lesser-known rural and tribal jewellery traditions.

Classic pastoral ideal

Part of a series edited by Pramod Kumar K.G. (co-founder of museum consulting company Eka Resources), and following Devdutt Pattanaik's *The Adornment of Gods* (2022), Balakrishnan's book documents hundreds of traditional Indian silver and gold jewels, largely from rural and tribal contexts. These works form part of the Amrapali Collection, of which about 800 pieces are displayed at their Jaipur museum.

Opened in 2018, the museum is one of the finest holdings of folk and ethnic jewellery and precious objects. The collection (amassed by founders Rajiv Arora and Rajesh Ajmera) emerged in the early 1980s from their passion for traditional jewellery, produced and worn mostly by rural, nomadic and tribal communities.

The urgency of their work – acquiring pieces from villagers, pawnbrokers, village silver- and



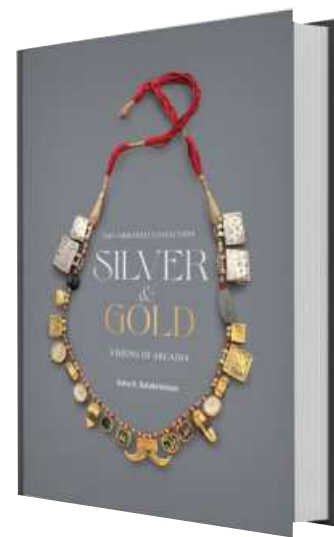
goldsmiths, antique dealers, auctions, and flea markets overseas – cannot be overstated: it has preserved forms that might otherwise have vanished.

In some regions, as I have seen first-hand, craftsmanship is rapidly disappearing, knowledge eroding, and tools and techniques discarded with



disquieting ease. In Badami, a small town in Karnataka, a young silversmith told me that no one locally could make by hand even a simple ovoid *lingam* case (*ayigalu* or *shivadhara*) carried by Lingayat community members – such as the gold-embellished example illustrated in the book (p. 45, fig. 12) – let alone the more complex *chauka* and *ayigalu* shown later (p. 142, figs. 60-61).

Rather than offering a fastidious string of catalogue entries for each object, which would have been unmanageable given the magnitude of the collection, the book – written in the mellifluous prose that characterises Balakrishnan's style – discusses selected jewels, mostly from the 19th and 20th centuries, to illuminate this



(Clockwise from left) The *lingam* casket; Himachali *pipla* (head ornament); book cover; Usha Balakrishnan; *kamarband* (waist ornament) from the Indo-Nepal border; *sankhla* (anklets) from Gujarat; *anguthi* (ring) from western India; *rupaya bazu* (armlet) from Orissa; and a bracelet from Gujarat. (THE AMRAPALI MUSEUM AND AMRAPALI FAMILY COLLECTION)

vernacular, pastoral jewellery tradition. The author relates it to *Arcadia*, the classical pastoral ideal of rustic innocence and quiet pleasure.

Valuable resource

The book is divided into five chapters (Genesis, Ethnos, Legacy, Materiality, and Creation) and addresses the key factors that shaped the making and use of these jewels, highlighting their significance to the communities of origin, including the techniques used in their manufacture. To achieve this, Balakrishnan draws on a rich array of archaeological, art-historical, documentary, literary, and ethnographic materials.

Her command of the bibliography is especially noteworthy, as it encompasses not only the art-historical literature specific to the material objects, but also the conceptual frameworks drawn from anthropology and ethnology that help us understand such objects more fully. If the study of princely jewels was once dismissed as inconsequential, research on folk jewellery, too often deemed 'primitive', 'mediocre' or 'unrefined', has attracted even harsher criticism – something that Balakrishnan's scholarly approach lays to rest.

Backed by technical labels and large illustrations, the book will be an invaluable resource for museum professionals, art historians and researchers, and will also inspire artists and designers to create new forms. There are, of course, jewels that one suspects were made and worn in more urban settings, but these are the exception.

While most are part of the Amrapali Foundation, some of the more spectacular pieces, usually in gold – such as the amulet necklace (*haar*) on the cover – belong to the Amrapali family collection. Beautifully produced by Mapin Publishing, this large-format book, with excellent photographs of the jewels by Umesh Gogna, is a feast for the eye as well as a scholarly work that mirrors the importance of the collection.

The writer is an art historian based in Lisbon.

Raja Sen

The Oscars are upon us. At a time when we are bemoaning the death of cinema and theatres, this has been an electrifying year for the movies. The race feels unusually alive, led by two prizefighters that are bonafide milestones: the satirical thriller *One Battle After Another* and the horror masterwork *Sinners*. It is rare to find two breathtaking classics – two proper all-time great movies – arriving at once, each defiantly reshaping our expectations of the big-screen film. Ryan Coogler's *Sinners* is loud, mythic and entirely uninterested in modesty. It throws images at us with the giddy confidence of a director who knows how vast his canvas can be.

Where *Sinners* is thunder, Paul Thomas Anderson's *One Battle After Another* is a symphony. The performances are more fiery, the direction more sensational, the cinematography jaw-dropping, and the music discordant, staying with you as you leave the theatre and doomsroll through bleak headlines. Coogler's blockbuster may leave a greater imprint on the culture, but *One Battle* features a maestro at his very peak. It deserves it all.

Will one of these visionary films hand Warner Bros. one final Best Picture trophy, before the studio folds into Paramount's corporate machinery in a few months? The narrative is classic and romantic: a grand old studio, curtain falling, trophy in hand. A last toast before

While there are fears that Paramount's merger with the studio may change the status quo, there is much to celebrate too



the lights go out. Before the vampires take over.

Ranging from silly to the strange Best Picture is a crowded table, and all the movies don't quite belong. There is *FI*, loud and silly and undeniably entertaining, the first Best Picture nominee in over 75 years without nominations for acting, writing or directing. It's in the mix so that Brad Pitt turns up. Chloé Zhao's *Hamnet* repackages Shakespeare to those who may not know enough Shakespeare – but without the self-awareness and soliloquy-love of former Best Picture winner *Shakespeare In Love* – and it feels like grief-porn wrapped in literary prestige.



Then there's *Marty Supreme*, that swaggering ping pong saga with a name like a Scorsese biopic, featuring Timothée Chalamet, who continues his campaign to become the most gifted and most insufferable young actor alive. Joachim Trier's *Sentimental Value* contains remarkably delicate performances, though the film ties its emotional threads together so

neatly that it doesn't ultimately satisfy. Guillermo del Toro's *Frankenstein* is visually ravishing, a gothic painting that feels disappointingly inert, as if the monster's pulse never quite arrives. Then there is *Train Dreams*, the widely acclaimed drama by Clint Bentley that everyone insists is wonderful and nobody (including me, at the time



Warner's last Oscar dance



of writing this piece) seems to have watched.

Kleber Mendonça Filho's *The Secret Agent*, however, is a tremendous film, elevated by Brazilian actor-director Wagner Moura delivering a scintillating performance in the lead role, one for the ages. And finally, we have Yorgos Lanthimos's *Bugonia*, the coolest film in the line-up. Strange, biting, and eerily perfect for an era when it feels the world might collapse before lunchtime.

The ones who deserve it Ethan Hawke is magic in the biographical comedy-drama *Blue Moon*. He is unlikely to win Best Actor for his work in the gorgeous

(Clockwise from left) Stills from *Frankenstein*; *One Battle After Another*; *Marty Supreme*; *The Secret Agent*; *Sentimental Value*; *Sinners*; and *Bugonia*.

and underrated film, though I do hope filmmaker Richard Linklater steals a Screenplay award away from the big two. My pick for Actress would be Emma Stone who storms fearlessly through *Bugonia* as a ruthless tech billionaire from another planet. She is unlikely to win another Best Actress prize though, since she has two already and one more would (deservedly) catapult her into conversations usually reserved for Meryl Streep and Katherine Hepburn.

Let us end, finally, with the best film that didn't get invited. Park Chan Wook's *No Other Choice* is a firecracker of a movie about unemployment, desperation, and the erasure of human worth in the age of automation and Artificial Intelligence. It is a film about empathy at a time when we don't have enough to spare. It is original and uncomfortable and eye-opening. No wonder the Academy wants us to look away.

The 98th Academy Awards will air tomorrow at 4.30 a.m.

The writer is a screenwriter, critic and columnist.